

Weakness (Generalized) and Fatigue - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1066 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Generalized weakness/fatigue assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published when-to-get-help guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Clinical background

- Persistent unexplained fatigue can be associated with sleep problems, mood disorders, anaemia, diabetes, thyroid disease, infection, or other medical conditions.
- Sudden focal weakness, chest pain, severe breathing difficulty, confusion, or reduced responsiveness is an emergency presentation.
- Fatigue lasting weeks or interfering with normal life warrants clinical assessment.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, are they pregnant/recently postpartum, and did weakness start suddenly or gradually? Clarify generalized versus one-sided/focal weakness and child feeding, behaviour, urine, and safeguarding concerns.
2. [YES_NO] Any unintentional weight loss, mood changes, or other new symptoms?
3. [OPEN_TEXT] Is this affecting daily activities?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Diabetes - Low Blood Sugar

Is a measured blood-glucose reading below 4 mmol/L, or are symptoms suggesting hypoglycaemia, in a person with diabetes?

A confirmed low reading or hypoglycaemia symptom pattern belongs in the authored Diabetes - Low Blood Sugar pathway.

2. Redirect → Diabetes - High Blood Sugar

Is a measured blood-glucose reading high, with thirst, frequent urination, vomiting, abdominal pain, drowsiness, or other hyperglycaemia symptoms?

A confirmed high reading or hyperglycaemia symptom pattern belongs in the authored Diabetes - High Blood Sugar pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there sudden one-sided weakness or numbness, slurred speech, chest pain, severe difficulty breathing, or is the person confused or difficult to rouse?

Universal emergency rule-out added ahead of the tiredness/fatigue guidance itself - sudden focal weakness or altered consciousness may indicate stroke or another acute emergency rather than simple fatigue.

1. Disposition level 50

Has the tiredness lasted a few weeks without a clear cause, is it affecting daily life, or is it accompanied by weight loss, mood changes, or gasping/snorting/choking sounds during sleep?

NHS.UK guidance recommends a GP visit for unexplained, persistent, or functionally-impairing tiredness, or tiredness with these associated symptoms.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this a normal, occasional tiredness with a clear cause and none of the features above?

NHS.UK guidance: it's normal to feel tired sometimes; sleep hygiene and lifestyle measures are appropriate first steps.

Advice

Qatar emergency generalized-weakness response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for sudden or one-sided weakness, inability to stand, confusion, fainting, seizure, abnormal breathing, chest pain, major bleeding, severe infection, pregnancy/postpartum danger signs, suspected poisoning, or an unwell/floppy child. Keep the person still and do not give food, drink, or medicine if consciousness or swallowing is impaired. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening or one-sided weakness; loss of consciousness, seizure, or confusion; abnormal breathing, chest pain, bleeding, or severe infection.

Routine fatigue follow-up

- Book a routine GP appointment to investigate persistent or unexplained tiredness.
- Call Back If: new symptoms develop; worsening weight loss.

Home care for occasional tiredness

- Maintain a balanced diet and regular activity, keep consistent sleep times aiming for 6-9 hours, relax before bed, and avoid smoking, excess alcohol, caffeine, and screens close to bedtime.
- Call Back If: tiredness persists for weeks; new symptoms develop.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for sudden or one-sided weakness, inability to stand, confusion, fainting, seizure, abnormal breathing, chest pain, major bleeding, severe infection, pregnancy/postpartum danger signs, suspected poisoning, or an unwell/floppy child. Keep the person still and

do not give food, drink, or medicine if consciousness or swallowing is impaired. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Tiredness and fatigue", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/tiredness-and-fatigue/> (page last reviewed 02 June 2023)

Provenance

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